

Session 2: Introductions & Conclusions

Introductions

Task 1: In small groups, discuss what the purpose of an introduction is - can you list some features that might/should be included in the introduction of some **academic writing**?



Task 2: How long do you think an introduction should be, roughly?

Task 3: Below is an introduction which has been divided into coloured sections – in your same group, can you 1) analyse what is happening in these sections and determine their purpose, and 2) see if any are the same that you identified in Task 1.

To what extent should home-working for non-customer facing staff in the insurance industry be encouraged?

Since the development of communication technology in the 1990s, companies with noncustomer facing staff have become increasingly interested in the money saving potential of encouraging their staff to work at home. This has been of especial interest to the insurance industry, which employs many technical staff, statisticians and risk assessors, who frequently work for long periods on numerical, data-base tasks. Scholars of management have also taken an interest in homeworking, arguing that it can improve employee well-being, whilst simultaneously saving costs and helping to drive profits. However, not all academics have agreed with this “win-win” categorisation of homeworking, arguing that team cohesiveness and productivity can be greatly weakened. After reviewing the arguments against homeworking (Humphrey, 2003; Peters, 2012) and for homeworking (Graves, 2012; Barlow, 2012), this essay will focus on Barlow (2012), who found that homeworking employees are likely to experience less distraction than their office based counterparts, although only when certain conditions are placed on them. Thus, I will argue that most managers of non-customer facing staff should encourage working from home, but only if certain pre-agreed conditions are imposed on eligible employees.

Black:

Purple:

Red:

Blue:

Green:

Task 4: Can you identify any of the same (or different) features in the introductions below?

Final Offer or Bluffing? A discussion of signs and actions for probing the sincerity of the ‘final offer’ statement.

An offer could be labelled as ‘final’ because the negotiator is genuinely ready to exit, or the negotiator wants to increase their power or perceived power and pressure the counterparty to make concessions to increase their gains (Fisher & Ury, 2011; Schweitzer & Croson, 1999). Negotiators can assess the creditability of the final offer by considering the counterparty’s bluffing motivation based on the interests, BATNA and negotiation type, and rehearsing cues from emotions and behaviours. Given this is a protracted negotiation, I assume several offers have been made previously. Once negotiators gathered enough bluffing signals, several actions can be undertaken to probe the statement’s sincerity while allowing the negotiation to continue gracefully. This essay is structured as follows. I first discuss the bluffing signs by evaluating interests, BATNA, emotion and behaviour. I then propose actions for probing the sincerity of the final offer statement according to their level of risks.

‘A world where fewer people smoke is better for everyone’ (Dawson & Verweij, 2010). In view of this, to what extent do you think that the sale and/or use of tobacco should be restricted?

Dawson & Verweij (2010:349), in a summary of the multiple health benefits of quitting smoking, conclude that we should “work towards increasing tobacco cessation worldwide”. Whilst the sale and use of tobacco is highly regulated in most countries, questions remain about whether or not such restrictions should be extended. Current regulation usually consists of high tax levies, age restrictions for purchasing and limits on public areas where one may smoke. The ethical justification for such strict controls is primarily the “Millian paradigm” (Dawson & Verweij, 2010:89): in other words, the argument that state control of a product is legitimate “for reasons of preventing harm to others” (ibid: 89). Unlike other legal drugs, tobacco use is directly responsible for damage to the health of people who are not choosing to use it through passive smoking. This essay will examine the “harm to others” argument and two other arguments (“the vulnerability argument” & the “justice and equity argument” (Dawson & Verweij, 2010:89-90)), before concluding that there exists no practical means to restrict or prohibit the sale of tobacco without causing disproportionate harm to society. However, it will also be argued that further restrictions on tobacco use would be ethically sound but difficult to implement in practice.

Task 5: The introduction in task 3 and the first introduction from task 4 both use “I” – is this OK? When is it OK, and when should it be avoided? What is your preference?

Task 6: You’ll have noted that introductions have some variety and don’t need to have the same information. They will have a similar shape, however. Do they go from specific information to general, or from general to specific? Why?

Task 7: The first sentence of an intro is called a ‘hook’ – it’s supposed to ‘catch’ the reader’s attention. Compare the three hooks; what has been done? Are there any other ways to begin?

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Task 8: What are the links between the hooks and the essay questions?

Task 9: The last sentence(s) of the introduction usually outline the writer’s stance (thesis) and essay outline. Please:

- Compare the ways the writers have given their stance/thesis (‘Thesis Statement’)
- Identify the similarity between the thesis statement and the essay question.
- Compare how they have outlined their essays – which do you like the most?

Task 10: Thesis statements and overviews can be combined into a single sentence, or separated – depending on the question and what you feel is best. These sentences are important, but are often written poorly – some problems are:

a. A non-thesis thesis:

Bad Thesis: This paper will consider the advantages and disadvantages of limiting free speech.

Better Thesis: While there may be advantages to restricting “hate speech”, the danger of restricting open dialogue on crucial racial issues is too great and too high a price to pay.

b. Overly broad:

Bad Thesis: The government has the right to limit free speech.

Better Thesis: The government has the right to limit free speech in cases of overtly racist or sexist language because our failure to address such abuses would effectively suggest that our society condones such ignorant and hateful views.

c. No structure:

Bad Thesis: There are many reasons we need to limit hate speech.

Better Thesis: Among the many reasons hate speech should be limited, the most compelling are a) ...b)...and c)...

Conclusions

Conclusions

Task 1: If an Introduction should be around 10% of your word count, how long should a conclusion be?

Task 2: Is there anything you should avoid doing in your conclusion? Can you use citations (in-text references) in the conclusion?

Task 3: There are generally three ‘parts’ in a conclusion - what do you think they are, and how are they organised? What should a conclusion do?

Task 4: In small groups, analyse the conclusions below – you read its introduction last week (*To what extent should home-working for non-customer facing staff in the insurance industry be encouraged?*)

In conclusion, managers of non-customer facing staff should certainly be doing far more to encourage staff to work from home, provided that they take into account the key findings of Barlow (2012). Data obtained from Barlow’s (2012) innovative SpectorSoft investigation suggests that managers can mostly allay their fears regarding distraction for homeworking employees, given the installation, with mutual consent, of Spy Software. Distractions, as defined by Humphrey’s (2003) now out-dated criticisms of homeworking, are no more likely to interfere with homeworkers than with their office-based counterparts. However, Barlow’s results, supported by Graves’s (2012) findings, also suggest that the setting of deadlines and regular appraisal of homeworking are essential conditions. In future, more work using SpectorSoft on employees working in different sectors might help to generalise Barlow’s (2012) results to office-based activities other than insurance.

Black:

Blue:

Green:

Task 5: Below is the thesis statement from the introduction – how does it link to 1) the first sentence of the conclusion above, and 2) the assignment title?

Thus, I will argue that most managers of non-customer facing staff should encourage working from home, but only if certain pre-agreed conditions are imposed on eligible employees.

Task 6: There are three common ways to end a conclusion – how did the writer conclude theirs? Do you know the other two ways?

Task 7: Below is the introduction in full. Please could you 1) Explain how the **blue** information from the conclusion differs from the content of the introduction, and 2) highlight any similarities between the two that you notice.

Since the development of communication technology in the 1990s, companies with noncustomer facing staff have become increasingly interested in the money saving potential of encouraging their staff to work at home. This has been of especial interest to the insurance industry, which employs many technical staff, statisticians and risk assessors, who frequently work for long periods on numerical, data-base tasks. Scholars of management have also taken an interest in homeworking, arguing that it can improve employee well-being, whilst simultaneously saving costs and helping to drive profits. However, not all academics have agreed with this “win-win” categorisation of homeworking, arguing that team cohesiveness and productivity can be greatly weakened. After reviewing the arguments against homeworking (Humphrey, 2003; Peters, 2012) and for homeworking (Graves, 2012; Barlow,2012), this essay will focus on Barlow (2012), who found that homeworking employees are likely to experience less distraction than their office-based counterparts, although only when certain conditions are placed on them. Thus, I will argue that most managers of non-customer facing staff should encourage working from home, but only if certain pre-agreed conditions are imposed on eligible employees.

Conclusions are often rushed and overlooked, but they should be given your full attention. They embody the whole point of your assignment, and they are last thing your tutor reads before deciding your grade.

Their structure is often as follows:

1. Re-state thesis statement; this is a clear link back to the question. This shows you’ve answered it.
2. A summary of your main argument, but in more detail than the intro (not too much detail, as you’ve done this in the body and there’s no need to repeat). You do this by:
 - a. Supporting sentences that summarise the points you’ve made, but showing how they relate to each other and how they support your thesis. **OR:**
 - b. Demonstrate how your response has supported the thesis more holistically (e.g. tackle the question itself more directly).
3. A final sentence, usually a recommendation, prediction or statement.

Task 8: Here is another Introduction/Conclusion pair. Spend some time with a partner to consider:

- 1) Does the introduction's thesis link to the question clearly?
- 2) What are your thoughts in general about the introduction, could it be improved?
- 3) Look at the conclusion – does it follow the advice box above?
- 4) Compare them; do these link together successfully? Is there any repeated language from the question?
- 5) What kind of last sentence did this student use?

Title: *"We can eliminate our cognitive biases by taking more time to make decisions."*
Discuss (1,500 words).

1.0 Introduction

Rushed decisions are unavoidable in life, but it has been proven that they can lead to systematic errors due to our cognitive biases (Tversky and Kahneman, 1974). One may believe that simply spending time to thoroughly consider the decision can save them from committing such mistakes. However, this essay will argue that while taking additional time can allow us to improve our decisions if used effectively, it cannot eliminate all our biases. This essay will identify common cognitive biases and discuss how they influence us when we make decisions quickly. Then, strategies of elimination of these biases will be examined. Finally, the essay will look at subconscious mental shortcuts and how they impact human decision making even when we are aiming to reach an optimal and bias-free conclusion.

5.0 Conclusion

To summarise, rapid human decision making is largely based on heuristics – mental short-cuts that influence our cognitive processes. Although they allow us to save time and make usually correct decisions with limited resources, they inevitably lead to systematic and predictable biases when left unchecked. Researchers propose that we can protect our decisions from such errors if we increase our effort and apply strategies that allow us to analyse the problem thoroughly. Here, the additional time will naturally allow us to improve the quality of the analysis. Nonetheless, the most critical aspect is the ability to identify our biases. Without the knowledge of common misconceptions, it is impossible to find our mistakes and correct them, as many of them are highly subtle and subconscious. It must be noted that even skilled decision-makers fall victim to logical fallacies. Moreover, even when we decide to make the additional effort to check our conclusions, it is common for people to spend time looking for proof of their initial thesis rather than challenge it. Unfortunately, the subtlety and strength of our cognitive biases make it close to impossible for an average person to notice them. Therefore, taking more time to make a decision is not a panacea that eliminates all of our biases.

Task 9: The writer here has made numerous style errors – constant pronouns ("we", "us", "our") make the introduction and conclusion appear less formal than they ought to be. Why do you think this has happened?

Task 10: Try to make some changes to the **conclusion** to make it more formal. When you finish, there is a suggested answer on the following page.

1.0 Introduction

Formal: Rushed decisions are often unavoidable, but it has been proven that they can lead to systematic errors due to cognitive biases (Tversky and Kahneman, 1974). One may believe that simply spending time to thoroughly consider the decision can avoid such mistakes. However, this essay will argue that while taking additional time can lead to improved decisions if used effectively, it cannot eliminate all biases. This essay will identify common cognitive biases and discuss their influence on quick decision-making. Then, strategies of elimination of these biases will be examined. Finally, the essay will look at subconscious mental shortcuts and how they impact human decision-making even when attempting to reach an optimal and bias-free conclusion.

Original: Rushed decisions are unavoidable in life, but it has been proven that they can lead to systematic errors due to our cognitive biases (Tversky and Kahneman, 1974). One may believe that simply spending time to thoroughly consider the decision can save them from committing such mistakes. However, this essay will argue that while taking additional time can allow us to improve our decisions if used effectively, it cannot eliminate all our biases. This essay will identify common cognitive biases and discuss how they influence us when we make decisions quickly. Then, strategies of elimination of these biases will be examined. Finally, the essay will look at subconscious mental shortcuts and how they impact human decision making even when we are aiming to reach an optimal and bias-free conclusion.

5.0 Conclusion

Formal: To summarise, rapid human decision making is largely based on heuristics – mental short-cuts that influence the cognitive processes. Although they allow for time saving and the making of correct decisions with limited resources, they inevitably lead to systematic and predictable biases when left unchecked. Researchers propose that decisions can be protected from such errors if effort is increased and strategies are applied that allow the problem to be analysed thoroughly. Here, the additional time will naturally result in improved quality of analysis. Nonetheless, the most critical aspect is the ability to identify individual biases. Without the knowledge of common misconceptions, it is impossible to find mistakes and correct them, as many of them are highly subtle and subconscious. It must be noted that even skilled decision-makers fall victim to logical fallacies. Moreover, even when additional effort to check conclusions is made, it is common for people to spend time looking for proof of their initial thesis rather than challenge it. Unfortunately, the subtlety and strength of cognitive biases make it close to impossible for an average person to notice them. Therefore, taking more time to make a decision is not a panacea that eliminates all biases.

Original: To summarise, rapid human decision making is largely based on heuristics – mental short-cuts that influence our cognitive processes. Although they allow us to save time and make usually correct decisions with limited resources, they inevitably lead to systematic and predictable biases when left unchecked. Researchers propose that we can protect our decisions from such errors if we increase our effort and apply strategies that allow us to analyse the problem thoroughly. Here, the additional time will naturally allow us to improve the quality of the analysis. Nonetheless, the most critical aspect is the ability to identify our biases. Without the knowledge of common misconceptions, it is impossible to find our mistakes and correct them, as many of them are highly subtle and subconscious. It must be noted that even skilled decision-makers fall victim to logical fallacies. Moreover, even when we decide to make the additional effort to check our conclusions, it is common for people to spend time looking for proof of their initial thesis rather than challenge it. Unfortunately, the subtlety and strength of our cognitive biases make it close to impossible for an average person to notice them. Therefore, taking more time to make a decision is not a panacea that eliminates all of our biases.